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'August 13 verdict delivered'

...as voter turnout falls short of expectations despite increased number of registered voters (Page 2)

Six nabbed with offensive weapons

By Alex Maboshe

Six have been arrested for possession of offensive weapons after police stopped their vehicle during a nationwide security operation today.

Speaking during a media briefing, Police Public Relations Officer Godfrey Chilabi said that officers recovered 22 rounds of ammunition and other items during a search of the vehicle.

He added that campaign materials belonging to Roma Independent parliamentary candidate Sean Tembo were also found inside.

Mr. Chilabi said police are calling on Tembo to present himself to assist with the ongoing investigations.

The arrests form part of a nationwide stop-and-search operation being conducted by police as voters cast their ballots across the country.

In a separate development, the Zambia Police Service reminded political parties, candidates, their supporters and members of the public to respect the 400-metre radius around polling stations, as required under Section 89 of the Electoral Process Act No. 35 of 2016.

Mr. Chilabi emphasised that anyone found interfering with the electoral process, intimidating election officers, polling agents or voters, or disrupting the peaceful conduct of elections faces a fine of up to 200,000 penalty units K80,000, imprisonment for up to two years, or both upon conviction.

He said the measures are intended to ensure a safe environment for citizens to exercise their democratic right to vote.



First Lady Mutinta Hichilema casting her vote at Kabulonga Boys Secondary School in Lusaka today. Picture by Ruth Kambita.

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Real News in Real Time

Work over voting?

By Linda Nyondo

A small but notable number of Zambians chose work over voting today, saying they needed to earn money to support their families.

Bright Habwema, a self-employed contractor, told reporters he had a deadline and could not afford to miss the day's work.

"I was engaged on a temporary basis. I have a deadline to meet, so I had to come for work," he said.

He added that the risk of losing the contract to someone else made earning a priority over joining the queue. "Making money is more important than going out to vote," he said.

Andrew Phiri, a Jehovah's Witness, said his religion prohibits him from participating in electoral politics.

"I will accept and support whoever is elected, but I will not go against my faith and belief," he said.

He complained that some Zambians were perennially ungrateful and quick to criticise leaders.

"Even if Jesus came from

heaven and began ruling us, we would still find fault with him," he said. Nonetheless, Mr Phiri urged citizens to exercise their democratic rights and warned against violence if their preferred candidate lost.

He advised unsuccessful aspirants to try again at the next general election.

A spot check across Lusaka indicated that many employers observed the government's declaration of the day as a public holiday to allow staff to vote.

Shoprite branches displayed notices announcing they would open at 14:00 to permit employees to participate.

Other businesses, including Hungry Lion and Nu Metro cinemas, remained open.

Hungry Lion management said staff had been split into two groups: one working the morning shift and voting in the afternoon, the other voting in the morning and returning to work later.

Observers said a minority displayed an indifferent attitude, opting not to vote without citing work, faith or logistics as reasons.

VPN free elections?

By Alex Maboshe

Members of the public have expressed surprise that mobile networks remained stable on polling day; defying expectations based on past election experiences.

However, it is not known if the statuesque will remain the same up to the declaration of the winner.

There is high likelihood that internet will remain intact following President Hakainde Hichilema post on Facebook that read "Sorry VPN providers"

In previous elections, including the 2021 general elections, widespread network disruptions forced many people to rely on VPNs to stay connected.

Last week, intermittent network drops in some parts of the country led residents to believe authorities were preparing for similar shut-

downs ahead of today's vote.

However, those predictions proved incorrect as no nationwide network disconnection has been reported.

Network shutdowns in past elections were typically

justified as measures to curb misinformation and prevent violence.

This year's general elections, however, have been widely regarded as among the most peaceful, with al-

most no reports of violence.

Many residents have welcomed the uninterrupted service, noting that they can now follow and monitor the electoral process across the country in real time.

'August 13 verdict delivered'

By Sam Phiri

Zambia has, in the space of twelve hours, taken a decisive turn as voters went to the polls and delivered their verdict.

The turnout, however, fell short of expectations despite an increased number of registered voters.

At Kamwala Primary School polling station at about 09:30, for example, only 132 people queued inside the school compound.

By contrast, at the same time and location in 2021, the line stretched for over

one and a half kilometres and contained more than 3,000 people.

Those who recall the mood of 2021 describe this year's atmosphere as marked by considerable voter apathy; a phenomenon that often signals an absence of appetite for change.

All voting is now complete and Zambians await the formal declaration from the Electoral Commission of Zambia to learn who will steer the country for the next five years.

The main contestants were the incumbent, President Hakainde Hichilema, and his challenger, former Mporokoso MP Brian Mundubile.

President Hichilema campaigned on continuity on economic gains, attracting both local and foreign

investment while maintaining macroeconomic reforms aimed at reducing inflation and creating jobs.

Mundubile emphasised a platform of what he describes as 'freedom' accountability and service delivery, promising a country that is centred on the young people and improved support for farmers and greater investment in healthcare and education.

Observers note that the 2021 contest which brought President Hichilema to power amid a wave of optimism against the previous administration set high expectations that appear to have tempered voter enthusiasm today.

The nation now waits for official results and the direction the next administration will take for the next five years.

Be patient, accept results – Rev Matale

By Ruth Kambita

Former Council of Churches in Zambia (CCZ) General Secretary Reverend Suzanne Matale has appealed for peace, patience and acceptance of results as the nation waits for the outcome of the poll.

Speaking in an interview with the Real Times Digital News shortly after casting her vote at Kabulonga Boys Secondary School in Lusaka today Rev Dr Matale said Zambians should by all means avoid arguments and confrontation after voting, adding that peace is essential for national unity and development.

The cleric said it is her prayer that people avoid

personality-based voting; saying citizens should choose leaders on merit and issues rather than village identity or personal dislike.

She said young people in particular should reject divisive politics and focus on building a better future.

Dr Matale further urged the youth to embrace hard work and entrepreneurship, telling them to start from the bottom and develop practical skills instead of relying on handouts or miracles.

She said churches also have a role in encouraging self-reliance and productive work among young people.

Her remarks came as polling in Lusaka and other parts of Zambia proceeded peacefully amid strong turnout.

Presidential candidates vote with confidence

By Ruth Kambita

President Hakainde Hichilema this afternoon cast his vote at Kabulonga Boys Secondary School in Lusaka amid cheers from supporters with a sea of journalists waiting to ask him that final question ahead of the announcement of the result.

The President arrived with First Lady Mutinta, his two sons, daughter and other family members at about 12:30.

Speaking to journalists after voting, Mr Hichilema said his administration had delivered on key campaign promises, including free education, debt restructuring and the restoration of the rule of law.

"This election is about the distinction between retrogression and violence, and peace, security and stability for development," Mr Hichilema said.

Other presidential candi-

dates who voted included Brian Mundubile, leader of the National Reconciliation Party for Unity and Prosperity, who cast his ballot at Olympia Park School in Lusaka. Mr Mundubile described his vote as one for the restoration of peace and unity.

Leadership Movement President Richard Silumbe confirmed he had voted, while Citizens First Party president Harry Kalaba cast his ballot at Linda P-U-S-H polling station in Makeni Constituency, Lusaka.

Christian Democratic Party president Danny Pule also voted.

The Electoral Commission of Zambia (ECZ) is currently counting ballots as the country awaits confirmation of its next leader.

All candidates say Zambians have chosen them, though the contest is primarily between Mr Hichilema and Mr Mundubile.



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The August 13, 2026 General Election day in pictures. Pictures by Ruth Kambita and Alex Maboshe-Real Times, Royd Sibajene, Wasamunu Mubita and Angela Lishungu ZANIS.



Man kills self over girlfriend talk

By Ruth Kambita

A 34-year-old man has taken his own life after a row with his wife, over talk about girlfriends.

The dispute began on August 4, 2026, when Catherine Banda overheard her husband Emmanuel Mwale now the deceased and a visitor, Kelvin Phiri of Kawere Village in Chief Kalindawalo's area, discussing girlfriends.

Mr Mwale later left to sleep at his mother's house. He returned home on August 11 to ask for forgiveness, but another argument broke out after he received a phone call from Mr Phiri.

Police said he later left home carrying a chitenge material and was found hanging on a tree in the yard around 05:00 hours the following morning by his wife.

Eastern Province Police Commanding Officer Robertson Mweemba said the body was inspected and no foul play was suspected.

Mr Mweemba said the remains were handed over to relatives for burial.

Meanwhile, a 40-year-old has taken his own life after a dispute with his wife over a bicycle borrowed from his mother-in-law, Evelyn Chaponda.

It is alleged that Clement Chilungu, now the deceased, had borrowed a Buffalo bicycle in July to visit his home village but returned without it on August 8.

The matter came to a head on August 12 when Idah Tembo asked her husband about the missing bicycle.

Mr Mweemba said later that day, Mr Chilungu was found dead hanging from the roof of their house with a chitenge material.

He said the body was examined and no foul play was suspected. The remains were released to relatives for burial.

Observers report election irregularities

By Linda Nyondo

Election observers have reported a series of irregularities at polling stations across the country, including the confiscation of voters' cards, delays to openings and inadequate facilities for vulnerable voters.

Ziko Late Consortium, speaking to the media, said it had received numerous reports suggesting that five

voters' cards were seized from a person suspected of being a party cadre, and that the individual was subsequently prevented from voting.

The group also received complaints about breaches of voter secrecy, with some voters allegedly observed while marking their ballots.

A delayed opening at a polling station in Ngombe led to a stampede in which a woman was injured and taken

to hospital unconscious, the consortium said. In Kasama, Ndoloka polling station did not open until 12:15 hours.

The consortium expressed concern that late openings were restricting people's opportunity to vote. It also reported that some polling stations had been relocated without notifying the electorate.

The moves to alternative, larger sites caused confusion,

in some cases, injuries among voters.

"We are concerned that such changes may have negative effects on the fairness of the process," consortium representative Austin Kayanda said.

Observers further noted inadequate provisions for vulnerable groups, including persons with disabilities and the elderly. Shortages of materials, such as indelible

ink, were reported in other areas, causing voting to stop temporarily and prompting frustration among voters.

There were also reports that journalists and police officers had been harassed. The consortium urged moderation in the deployment of security personnel and called on Zambians to remain peaceful and calm while voting and awaiting the announcement of results.

DR Congo
club AS
Simba
invited for
pre-season
tourney

By Benedict Tembo

DR Congo club AS Simba will next weekend guest the four-club tournament to be staged at Arthur Davies in Kitwe and Levy Mwanawsa Stadium in Ndola.

The tournament will feature MTN Super League defending champions Power Dynamos, last year's runners-up Red Arrows and Zesco United.

The high-profile pre-season international tournament is designed to help Power and Arrows who will be representing Zambia in the CAF inter-club competitions.

Power open the 2026-2027 TotalEnergies CAF Champions League campaign against Al Merrikh of Sudan next month.

They play away first in Rwanda where Al Merrikh are based on September 6 before hosting the Sudanese giants in the return leg in Ndola.

Arrows on the other hand will be representing Zambia in the CAF Confederation Cup.

Arrows have been drawn against Madagascar's FC Rouge in the first preliminary round of the 2026-27 CAF Confederation Cup.

The Airmen will begin their continental campaign at home during the September 4 - 6 window before travelling to Madagascar for the decisive return leg scheduled for September 11- 13, 2026.

Should they progress on aggregate, they will advance to the second preliminary round and meet South African's Kaizer Chiefs.

The first leg of that tie is set for 16 -18 October, with the return fixture to be played from 23 - 25 October 2022.

U-20 ruggers back from Uganda wiser after tough Barthes Trophy campaign



By Benedict Tembo

The Zambia Under-20 rugby team has returned home after their Barthes Trophy campaign in Uganda.

The boys left Kampala with valuable lessons and experience—and, most importantly, a strong response to a difficult opening result.

After an 81–0 defeat to Uganda in their first encounter, the young team returned for their second match with a different mindset.

Uganda won again, 27–12, but this time Zambia competed for much longer, put points on the board and made Uganda work for the result.

The Zambia Rugby Union (ZRU) said the difference between 81–0 and 27–12 was more than a scoreline.

“It represents response, character and growth.

“Redemption in sport does not always mean turning defeat into victory.

Sometimes, it means showing that you have learned, responded and refused to be defined by one difficult performance,” the ZRU said.

The Union said the young players were learning what international rugby demands—physically, mentally and tactically.

“They need guidance, support and encouragement as they grow and represent Zambia with pride,” the ZRU

said. The first game exposed the gaps, but the second showed that those gaps can be narrowed.

Now comes the most important part: building on it.

“Welcome home, boys. The journey continues, and the future of international men’s rugby in Zambia is being built,” the ZRU said.

Kangwanda earns Yanga Shield on his Tanzania league debut

By Benedict Tembo

Albert ‘Dedo’ Kangwanda has announced his arrival in Tanzanian football, scoring the match winner as Young Africans beat Simba 1-0 in the Community Shield in Zanzibar on Wednesday.

Kangwanda’s debut goal in the Kariakoo Derby played Amaan Complex came in the 31st minute.

“Happy to have scored my debut goal in an intense Derby, first of many to come,” the striker wrote on his Facebook page after the match.

Kangwanda made his debut for Tanzanian marquee club during the Yanga Day last Sunday against Les Aigles du Congo.

Kangwanda joined Yanga from MTN Super League side

Red Arrows last month on a permanent transfer.

Kangwanda left Nkoloma after an impressive spell with the Airmen following his return to the club, where he once again proved his quality as one of the league’s most lethal forwards.

The prolific striker played a pivotal role in the

club’s successful 2025-2026 ABSA Cup triumph and was equally instrumental in helping the Airmen secure a runners-up finish in the MTN Super League.

His outstanding performances throughout the 2025-2026 season, during which he finished as the club’s leading scorer and clinched the MTN Super League player of the season award, underlined his importance to the team’s attacking ambitions and endeared him to the Arrows faithful.